

LEGACIES OF THE WAR

1877

The Civil War was by far the bloodiest in American history, with most families, North and South, suffering some form of loss. This had lasting effects—disabled veterans were a common sight into the 20th century, and pension payments to veterans long remained a major cost. Wars often produce unexpected consequences, too—few in the North had sought the abolition of slavery when the war began, but it had come to pass. The struggle had been asymmetrical at its start, and its consequences were equally so. The war had inspired industrial and economic growth in the North; conversely some 60 percent of Southern wealth was destroyed or, in the case of the capital value of enslaved people, abolished in the war.

The other of the war's great issues, the doctrine of states' rights, met a decisive setback. The Federal government had taken and used powers that would have seemed excessive in 1860, setting about the establishment of a national banking system, imposing an income tax, creating a huge railroad corporation, and much else. Much of this came about through the impetus of war and the same enthusiasm for radical change persisted to some extent into the postwar years. But the far-reaching Reconstruction measures attempted by Congress into the early 1870s soon met intransigent opposition in the South and became mired in political squabbles in Washington, D.C. By the 1870s, the North no longer had much interest in sorting out Southern problems, and white veterans on both sides spoke increasingly of reconciliation. Whites soon regained most of their economic and political dominance in the South. Those who had previously been enslaved were able to lead real family lives and have some control over their futures, but the political changes hinted at in the postwar constitutional amendments and civil rights laws still lay far ahead.

